



# FEATHER FABLES

A journey through the world of birds



P. Radhakrishna Pai

*RK Pai Photography*

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P. Radhakrishna Pai

*Mathru Kripa, Vittal*

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| <i>Published by</i>            | : Bharathi Janardhana Prakashana<br>Car Street, Vittal – 574243<br>Mob: 9448472207                                                         |
| <i>Photos &amp; Written by</i> | : P. Radhakrishna Pai<br>Mathru Kripa, Vittal<br>Mob.: 9448472207                                                                          |
| <i>Pages</i>                   | : 104 + 4                                                                                                                                  |
| <i>Price</i>                   | : ₹ 2779/-                                                                                                                                 |
| <i>Printed at</i>              | : Hanuman Printers, Vittal - 574243<br>Opp. Pvt. Bus Stand, Bantwal Taluk, D. K.<br>Mob: 9964399015<br>Email: hanumanprintersvtl@gmail.com |
| <i>DTP &amp; Cover Design</i>  | : Vratihik Shenoy K., Kasaragod                                                                                                            |
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द्वा सुपर्णा सयुजा सखाया समानं वृक्षं परिषस्वजाते ।  
तयोरन्यः पिप्पलं स्वाद्वत्त्यनश्नन्नन्यो अभिचाकशीति ॥

- Dva Suparna: Two birds with beautiful wings.
- Sayuja Sakhaya: Inseparable companions and friends.
- Samanam Vriksham: Dwelling on the same tree.
- Parishasvajate: Are perched/embracing the tree.
- Tayo Anya: Of the two, one (the individual soul).
- Pippalam Svadu Atti: Eats the fruit (of the tree) with relish.
- Anyah Anasnan: The other, without eating.
- Abhichakashiti: Merely looks on as a witness.

**The Metaphorical Symbolism:**

1. The Tree: Represents the Body or the material world (Prakriti).
2. The First Bird (Jivatma): Represents the Individual Soul or

the Ego. This bird is busy eating the fruits of the tree—some sweet (pleasure) and some bitter (pain). It is deeply involved in the world and affected by its joys and sorrows.

3. The Second Bird (Paramatma): Represents the Supreme Soul or Pure Consciousness. This bird sits on a higher branch, calm and silent. It does not eat the fruit; it simply watches the first bird. It is the eternal witness (Sakshi), unaffected by the world. The philosophical lesson: the Upanishad explains that as long as the first bird (the person) identifies with the “eating” (the actions and results), it remains anxious and unhappy. However, the moment it looks up, recognizes the second bird, and realizes that its true nature is actually that of the silent witness, it becomes free from grief and attains liberation (Moksha).

# *Blessed Moments with Daaji*



Meditation has transformed my life in a beautiful and meaningful way. Under the blessings and guidance of Daaji, I discovered greater peace, balance, and clarity in my thoughts, behaviour, and lifestyle. Heartfulness meditation, guided by Daaji, helped me connect deeply with my inner self and experience the quiet strength of the heart. His simple yet profound teachings continue to inspire millions to live with love, balance, and inner harmony. This inner journey slowly reflected in every part of my life — in my routine business, my love for birding, and my passion for photography. Nature began to speak more deeply to my heart, and every moment became a lesson in mindfulness and gratitude. Through meditation, I learned to live with patience, compassion, and simplicity. In every step of my journey, I continue to seek the blessings of Daaji, whose wisdom inspires me to walk through life with harmony, joy, and inner peace.



*Written by: P. Radhakrishna Pai*

# *My Journey of Photography*



My interest in photography began with beautiful stories and curiosity. After completing my education, I used to visit Geetha Studio near our shop in Vittal every day. The studio was owned by Late Mr. Keshava Nayak and Late Madhumathi akka. Watching them work kindled my passion — slowly, I learned the basics of photography, film developing, and printing in dark rooms. Those were the days of black and white photos, and digital cameras were unheard of — photography was all about patience and light. Later, I joined our grocery wholesale and retail business, and my photography passion paused for nearly forty years.

One day, my childhood friend Late Mr. Keshava Vittal, a talented photo journalist who had worked for many leading newspapers as well as his own studio, visited me. One of his relatives had opened a new studio in Vittal and wanted to sell a Canon DSLR camera. He encouraged me to buy it, and I agreed. That moment marked the rebirth of my photographic journey.

Slowly, I began capturing again, upgraded my cameras and lenses, and improved my skills. A friend then suggested I open a Facebook account, where I started posting my photos of birds. Day by day, the appreciation I received from people inspired me to move my hobby to the next level. Through this, I made many birding and photography friends across India and the world.

In my early days, I didn't know much about birds or their habitats. One day, after I posted a picture of a bird, Mr. Shiva Shankar from Karkala commented with the correct name. Later, he gifted me his book "Birds of Coastal Karnataka" — filled with his own photographs. That book became a great guide and motivation

for me.

Even today, I continue this beautiful journey. I've learned that photography is not just about clicking pictures — it's about capturing memories, building friendships, and connecting deeply with nature.

*Written by: P. Radhakrishna Pai*





# *My Family and Our Legacy*



My father, Late P. Janardhan Pai, and my mother, Late Smt. Bharathi Pai, are the foundation and inspiration of my life. My father started our business journey at the young age of sixteen, from zero, with hard work, honesty, and strong determination. Through his dedication, he built a respected business empire in Vittal.

Along with being a visionary businessman, he was also a writer in Kannada, a man of charity, and a pillar of society. His greatest ambition was to support education, especially the government school in Vittal, healthcare, and temple development in our hometown, Vittal.

Together, as a family, we worked to fulfil all his noble dreams, creating permanent projects in schools, hospitals, and temples that continue to benefit the community.

My mother, Late Smt. Bharathi Pai, was the divine strength behind our family — a goddess in human form. Her love, patience, and endless care have been our greatest blessing. She was a perfect homemaker and the emotional backbone of our family, supporting all good deeds and encouraging every step of progress.

I am blessed with a loving family of my own. My wife, Anuradha Pai, is my lovely life partner and constant source of encouragement — she stands by me at every moment with care and understanding.

We are blessed with twin daughters, Shraddha and Shreya, who have grown into graceful, well-educated, and cultured women. They both got married to twin brothers — Sanket Phadnis and Saurabh Phadnis, and are now well-settled in Mumbai with the blessings of my parents.

My younger brother, Subraya Pai, and my sisters Smt. Kalpana Nayak and Smt. Shubhakiran Shenoy,

have always been pillars of love and support. Together, our family stands as one — built on faith, values, and gratitude.

Truly, I owe everything to my parents and family, whose blessings guide every step of my life.

*Written by: P. Radhakrishna Pai*



*Late P. Janardhan Pai & Late Smt. Bharathi Pai*

# *Moments Across Miles*



During my birding and photography journey, I have been fortunate to capture more than 1000 different species of birds and animals from all over India — and even from the wild plains of Maasai Mara, Kenya, Tanzania, and South Africa.

Along with wildlife, I have also photographed temples, landscapes, and the beauty of nature through my lens.

In this first book, I have chosen to present some of my most memorable bird photographs along with a few animal images from Maasai Mara. Each frame holds a story — of patience, learning, and love for the wild.

I humbly request you to share this book with your friends and family, and above all, respect nature and love all living beings. Places visited for bird photography include almost all parts of Karnataka, including Ranganathittu, Kokkare Bellur, Hesaraghatta, Maidanahalli (Blackbuck Reserve), Banavasi, Mundagod, Mulky, Mangaluru, Bantwal, Alangar, Vittal, along with Kuduremukha, Durga WLS (Karkala), Kundapur, Coorg, Uttara Kannada, and other places in India, like Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, Uttarakhand, Kerala, and Goa.

Places visited outside India include Maasai Mara (Kenya), Tanzania, and South Africa.

— *P. Radhakrishna Pai*

# *My Observation*



In a world that often rushes by, where the cacophony of daily life drowns out the subtle whispers of nature, P. Radhakrishna Pai's journey into photography and connection with the avian world is something many of us might overlook.

Radhakrishna's narrative is not just about the technicalities of bird photography; it is a heartfelt exploration of passion, patience, and perseverance. From the early days of black-and-white photography in a modest studio to the vibrant colours of the digital age, his journey encapsulates the evolution of an artist who has remained true to his roots while embracing new challenges. It is a testament to the idea that it is never too late to pursue one's passions, and that the seeds of creativity, once sown, can flourish at any stage of life. Through his lens, Radhakrishna invites us to slow down and observe the intricate details of nature. Each photograph tells a story, revealing the unique characteristics and behaviours of birds. His ability to capture these moments reflects not only his technical skill but also his deep respect for the natural world.

Radhakrishna's interactions with fellow birders and nature enthusiasts showcase the sense of community that photography can foster. As you turn the pages of this book, may you find inspiration in Radhakrishna's journey. Let it encourage you to explore the beauty of your surroundings, to cultivate your passions, and to cherish the moments that nature provides. In a time when we often seek solace in screens, may his photographs serve as a bridge, connecting us to the extraordinary life that unfolds beyond our windows.

I am honoured to present this collection, a true reflection of a life dedicated to photography and a heartfelt

homage to the wonders of the natural world. May it inspire you to look closer, appreciate more, and perhaps even embark on your journey into the captivating realm of photography.

Read together, these reflections trace a single arc. A childhood fascination at Geetha Studio, kept alive by the encouragement of friends, slowly ripened into a lifelong passion — proof that inspiration often returns to us through the people who simply believe in our gift. From a novice fumbling with film to a photographer fluent in light and timing, Radhakrishna's progress speaks to the quiet virtues this craft asks of its makers: patience to wait, discipline to keep returning, and the humility to keep learning. Bird photography demands all three in equal measure. The bird never arrives on schedule; the photographer must.

What threads through every frame is something larger than technique — a deep bond between the photographer and the natural world. Through his lens, the beauty and diversity of wildlife find a witness, and the reader is gently invited to look closer at the small lives unfolding just beyond our windows. There is, in this looking, an implicit call: to appreciate, and to protect. And there is a quieter pleasure too, running beneath the rare sightings — the simple joy of being present in a forest, of listening, of finding gratitude in the small, fleeting moments that other lives might overlook.



None of this happens alone. The friendships Radhakrishna has built — with fellow photographers, mentors, and the wider birding community — have enriched the journey at every turn, transforming a solitary craft into a shared one. And in gathering these images into a book, there is the wish to pass something forward: a body of memories, an inheritance of attention, a legacy for those who come after.

Taken together, these threads reveal the transformative power of photography and nature — how they can shape one's identity, values, and connections with the world.



*K. Ullas Kamath*

*A relative, friend and an ardent admirer of dear  
Radhakrishna.*

# *Dva Suparna...*



This itself is Tapas (austerity). There is no doubt about it. Patience, faith, precision, understanding, endurance of hardship, and deep concentration — when all these are refined and matured, that itself becomes Tapas. It is a meditative state of being.

For the sake of a single photograph, the mind remains silently absorbed in meditation, always praying that the bird searching for its nest may have its wings strengthened until it reaches its goal. Those who understand say that a photographer becomes what he meditates upon. Creation is an act of joy performed in a semi-awakened state, and neither the detail nor the destiny of creation is known to anyone in advance.

Just as the bird, in a meditative state, patiently waits for its goal, the one who photographs it also waits, becoming a beautiful part of that very bird's journey. When the bird achieves its goal, the joy it experiences is the same joy the photographer feels after capturing the image.

It gives us great happiness to write these words about my dear friend Radhakrishna Pai. Along with the many photographs he has already published, he has spent countless meaningful moments for many more unpublished images that still reside within him. In this commercial world, possessing such a contemplative and sensitive mind is no small thing.

From the depths of my heart, I extend my best wishes to this work being published, and to its creator, my young friend Radhakrishna Pai.



— *M. Ananthakrishna Hebbar*  
*“Saaranga”, Vittal*

# *May Everyone's Hearts Turn Towards Nature*



It gives me great pleasure to convey my best wishes for your bird photography journey and this book. Though I am a Judge by profession, my roots are deeply connected to our hometown and my ancestral home near the western coast and the Kelanje Māle forest. My childhood memories amidst nature have nurtured a lifelong bond with forests and wildlife.

Those early experiences with nature give me a special perspective to appreciate and encourage your dedication to bird photography. Through your lens, birds find a voice, and nature finds renewed meaning. May this book inspire many to observe, respect, and protect the natural world.

With warm wishes for your continued journey in photography and the conservation of nature.



—*Jayaprakash V.*  
*Senior Civil Judge & Judicial Magistrate First Class,*  
*Sakleshpura.*

# *The Quiet Joy of Photography*



Pablo Picasso, the celebrated artist, once said, “The meaning of life is to find your gift; the purpose of life is to give it away.”

Radhakrishna Pai, in this repertoire of pictures, makes an effort to capture this very spirit!

There is a special kind of magic that happens when the photographer does not chase the moment but waits for it. His photography invites you to slow down, breathe, and truly see nature as it exists, where flora and fauna share a heartbeat. Coexistence exists.

His pictures are worth a thousand words. The stunning close-ups, the breathtaking wildlife moments! These compelling pictures showcase his journey of birdwatching.

“We often do not encounter rare species, so his repertoire of pictures is the first step in acknowledging their value and the need for protecting Mother Nature.”

Think of this book as a storytelling endeavour that celebrates a relationship between people and birds and the ecosystem that is the very sustenance of life on this earth.

May he continue to enrich our knowledge of birds... “Angels of the sky”!

Enjoy...



*Arundhati Dhareshwar*  
*“Parijata” Vittal*

# *Pai's This Venture Has Re-Ignited My Love for Life*



Many years back when I was going to Late Janardhan Pai's shop for my home needs, I was observing his teenage son Radhakrishna Pai. Later both R. K. Pai and I joined JCI of Vittal and were attending regular meetings. Then one after another both of us were elected as presidents of the Vittal chapter of the organisation and our chapter hosted conferences in our town during both of our periods! Both of us were members of the Vittal Jaycees Education Society, Vittal, and later became Secretary and Director respectively, and we became close.

His father, the late Janardhana Pai, started a business and established many industries in Vittal. He was a philanthropist and was in education and religious fields apart from showing interest in literature. Radhakrishna Pai expanded and diversified his father's business and industry and gave employment to many youths. He showed his interest in photography, especially of birds! He continued his work in education and religious fields as well. Mr. Pai's photography was not only in many places of our state and other Indian states but also abroad including Africa.

Because of my old age, I slowly withdrew myself from Jaycee Training, Jaycee School, book publication and grammar teaching in various schools. Hence, I was away from almost all social activities. One fine day, Mr. Pai gave me his writings about his photographic experience to read. Suddenly, after reading them, my mood changed, and I started to love and live life once again. Such was his enthusiasm, commitment, and dedication in bird photography. His writings exhibited his love for birds and his respect for Mother Nature!



I hope this book reaches many people and wish his bird photography and his business a bright future.

From the depths of my heart, I extend my best wishes to this work being published, and to its creator, my young friend Radhakrishna Pai.



*Shridhar Kodakkal*  
*Author and Publisher of Educational Books and*  
*Senior Trainer of JCI – India.*

# *My Elder Brother's Endeavour*



It is a feeling of privilege to write about my elder brother Radhakrishna Pai's passion for bird photography. I remember the words of my Guru, who once said that we should all chase a hobby which will ultimately help us in our fifties to lead a balanced life. Being a busy man, running multiple family-owned businesses while simultaneously chasing his passion and hobbies is not an easy task. But my brother is able to find time for both with fine balance. I truly appreciate his photography journey; it is one that makes him a true lover of nature and fuels his growth as a refined human being. Hearty congratulations to him on his maiden book release on the eve of his successful completion of sixty years. My sincere prayers to the Almighty to bless him with tons of happiness, health, success, and prosperity in the coming years, with lots of time to pursue his hobbies and passion.



*With Love*  
*P. Subraya Pai*

# *My Life Partner*



It's a very special and emotional moment for me. I feel incredibly happy and proud that my husband has written a book on his bird photography journey — what began as a simple hobby has grown into his passion and a beautiful expression of his deep love for nature.

He started this journey nearly 15–16 years ago. In those early days, when he would go out with his friends for photography, I used to feel a little upset. After our marriage, we were not just partners, but the best of friends, doing everything together. So when his weekends slowly became dedicated to birding trips, I often found myself feeling lonely. But today, my heart is filled only with pride and admiration.

I have witnessed his dedication, his progress, and the quiet determination with which he followed his passion. What amazes me the most is this—he may not have patience for many things in life, but when it comes to waiting for birds, it is endless. That patience, that love, and that commitment are what have brought him to this moment.

“A birder in the true sense.”

This book is not just about photography; it is a reflection of his journey, his perseverance, and his love for the natural world.

I am truly proud of you.



*With Love*  
*Anuradha Pai*

# *From My Twin Daughters*



Growing up, we have always known our father as a man of many passions. Long before this beautiful collection of birds and photographs came into being, he was someone who found joy in creativity — whether through photography, painting, or lovingly crafting our family’s Ganesh Chaturthi idols each year. Creativity was never just a hobby for him — it was simply a part of who he was.

In our childhood years, responsibilities came first. With the weight of family and business duties on his shoulders, much of his time was devoted to ensuring stability and security, taking care of everyone around him. Yet, even during those busy years, his curiosity for the world and his love for nature quietly remained alive within him. After the demise of his father, as life slowly allowed him moments of pause and personal time, he began returning to his passion — photography — with renewed dedication. What started as small moments carved out of a busy routine gradually transformed into a journey of patience, discovery, and deep connection with nature.

Behind this journey has always stood our mother, a constant pillar of support. In the early days, she would sit at the shop so he could step away to photograph birds and wildlife, encouraging him to pursue what brought him happiness. Her belief in his passion gave his dreams the space to grow. Today, it is heartwarming to see how their journey has evolved from quiet support to shared adventures, with both of them now exploring forests, landscapes, and the beauty of nature together. Listening to her speak about these experiences and the joy she finds in them makes us realize how passions, when nurtured, bring happiness not

just to one person but to an entire family.

To the world, this book may be a remarkable collection of bird photography — a showcase of patience, skill, and artistic vision. But to us, it tells a deeper story. It reflects a man who has always been an all-rounder, balancing duty with dreams, family with personal passion, and responsibility with creativity. Beyond his many talents, he is also someone who finds joy in the simple warmth of home. The way he steps into the kitchen to help our mother, taking time to cook and lovingly preparing delicious dishes for us, is just another glimpse of the care and affection he pours into family life. Moments like these make us realize how beautifully he embodies the qualities of a perfect family man — someone who blends dedication, creativity, love, and warmth so effortlessly.

As his children, we have witnessed the sincerity he brings to everything he does. He has taught us, not through words but through example, the importance of following what brings joy, making time for oneself, and pursuing passions regardless of life's stages.

Today, as we see both our parents embracing this phase of life — free from earlier responsibilities and finally taking time for themselves — our hearts are filled with pride and happiness. Watching them do what they truly love, exploring nature together and finding joy in simple moments, is perhaps the greatest reward for all the years they devoted to family.

This book is more than a collection of photographs; it is a reflection of patience, passion, and a lifelong love for nature. As his daughters, we feel immense pride in celebrating not only his talent but the person he is — loving, dedicated, and endlessly inspiring.

With love and admiration,

We wish him continued joy, success, and countless more flights of discovery through the world of birds and beyond.



*Written by: Shraddha Pai Phadnis and Shreya Pai Phadnis*



# *Prose and Poetry of Nature*

*The National Bird of India – Indian Peafowl,  
Pride of Indian Wilderness 🇮🇳*



At the break of dawn, I began my journey from Vittal towards the misty hills of Kuduremukha, carrying not only my camera but also the quiet excitement that every wildlife photographer understands.

The morning roads were calm, wrapped in the soft light of sunrise, as I reached Anekere Karkala and parked near our gathering point — the small, well-known hotel beside Anekere, where countless travelers begin their day with warmth and friendship. Already seated at the table were Rajmohan, Kartik Bhat, and Rangaraj Prabhu, their faces glowing with the enthusiasm of another adventure into nature.

At 6:30 in the morning, amidst laughter and birding discussions, we enjoyed simple yet unforgettable delicacies — soft Buns with Thove, Avalakki Mosaru, steaming Hesaru, and hot coffee that blended perfectly with the chill of the early air. With hearts refreshed, we resumed our journey towards Kuduremukha.

Nature, as always, had prepared a surprise for us. On the roadside, perched gracefully upon the branch of a beautiful tree, sat our National Bird — the magnificent male Indian Peafowl.

Bathed in the golden touch of morning light, he appeared like a royal guardian of the forest, calm and proud. His shimmering plumage glowed with shades of emerald, sapphire, and bronze, while his elegant posture reflected the timeless beauty of the wild.

For a few magical moments, he remained still, as if understanding our admiration, generously offering us the chance to capture his splendid pose through our lenses. The forest was silent except for the gentle rustle of leaves and the soft clicks of our cameras — moments where photography becomes more than an art; it becomes gratitude towards nature.

That morning near Kuduremukha was not merely about photographing a bird. It was about friendship, travel, simple food, laughter, and the blessing of witnessing beauty in its purest form. And among all the memories of that journey, the proud Indian Peafowl on that roadside tree remains etched in my heart like a living painting from the wilderness.

*Karnataka's Feathered Beauty – State Bird  
of Karnataka, Indian Roller*



One peaceful early morning, along with my birding friends Madhushekar and Suresh Kamath, I reached the beautiful grasslands of Hesaraghatta to begin our birdwatching journey. The cool breeze, the golden light of sunrise, and the awakening sounds of nature created a perfect beginning for the day.

As we slowly explored the open landscape, nature gifted us a memorable moment. Perched gracefully on the delicate branch of a small plant sat the magnificent Indian Roller — the proud State Bird of Karnataka. Its vibrant shades of blue, turquoise, and brown glowed beautifully under the soft morning light, making the bird appear like a living jewel of the wilderness.

The bird remained calm and patient, generously allowing us enough time to observe, compose, and capture its elegant poses through our cameras. Every click of the shutter carried excitement, admiration, and gratitude for the beauty unfolding before us.

That morning was not only about photographing a beautiful bird. It also became a valuable learning experience for me. My friend Madhushekar from Bangalore shared simple yet meaningful guidance on how to improve wildlife photography — from understanding light and angles to patiently waiting for the perfect moment. His words reminded me that wildlife photography is not merely about cameras or lenses, but about observation, patience, respect for nature, and the ability to connect with the wild silently.

The sight of the Indian Roller perched gently against the morning sky remains one of my cherished memories from Hesaraghatta. A small bird on a tiny branch, a few friends united by passion, and the quiet lessons of nature. Together they created a beautiful chapter in my journey through wildlife photography.



# *The Hill Melody*



In the misty forests of Coorg, morning broke with the scent of coffee blossoms and the hum of life hidden among the trees. As sunlight filtered softly through the canopy, the forest awoke in golden whispers.

Amid this calm beauty, a gentle flutter caught my eye — the Yellow-browed Bulbul, perched gracefully on a mossy branch. Its bright yellow feathers glowed against the green, and its sweet, clear call echoed through the hills like a melody of joy.

It was pure poetry — the blend of light, song, and silence. It reminded me that in Coorg, every sunrise carries a song, and every bird adds a note to nature's endless symphony.

# *The Royal Grey*



In the leafy avenues of Mysore, where ancient trees tell stories of time, the morning air was filled with the fragrance of rain-soaked earth. As I looked up, sunlight streamed through the branches — and there it was, the Indian Grey Hornbill, perched high, calm and regal.

Its large curved bill and soft grey plumage blended beautifully with the old tree bark, a true guardian of the canopy. Every gentle movement, every call echoed with quiet strength — a reminder of how gracefully nature weaves majesty into simplicity.

This serene encounter in Mysore's green heart made me realize — some of nature's greatest wonders do not dazzle with colour but with their quiet dignity.



# *The Grace of the Grasslands*



In the grasslands of Saswad, Maharashtra, the morning sun painted the fields with a soft glow. Alongside my birding companion Datta Nagre, I scanned the open plains where wind and silence danced together.

Suddenly, out of the tall grass, rose a striking sight — the Crested Bunting (male), shining in deep black and chestnut tones, its tiny crest swaying gently in the breeze. It perched proudly on a dry stem, as if posing for the morning light itself.

Time paused — just the bird, the song of the wind, and the golden horizon! That elegant little bird reminded me that even the smallest life in nature carries the beauty and pride of creation.

# *The Emerald Whisper*



In the lush green hills of Lathchapper, West Bengal, the morning mist drifted like silk through the forest. Alongside my birding friend Debpratim Shah, I followed the melody of unseen wings and the whisper of the wind through bamboo leaves.

Then, in a beam of soft sunlight, the forest offered its jewel — the Common Green Magpie. Its emerald feathers glowed against the dark woods, eyes bright with curiosity, and tail gliding like a ribbon of light.

We watched in silent awe as it called out softly, vanishing back into the emerald shade. This fleeting moment stayed within — a reminder that nature's beauty often reveals itself in silence, just long enough to touch the soul.

# *The Flame of Coorg*



Nestled in the misty hills of Coorg, where coffee blossoms scent the air and streams sing softly through emerald valleys, nature reveals her finest art. On one such peaceful morning, camera in hand, I wandered through the dew-kissed woods, listening to the awakening forest.

Amid the symphony of chirps and rustling leaves, a sudden flash of colour caught my eyes — the Flame-throated Bulbul, glowing like a spark of fire in the green mist. Its bright throat shone against the dark foliage, a living gem of the Western Ghats.

For a moment, the world stood still — only the song of the bird, the whisper of the breeze, and the fragrance of Coorg's wild heart remained. In that silence, I felt the soul of nature itself.

Coorg's true beauty, I realized, is not just in its landscapes but in the little lives that fill its forests with music and light.



# *The Gem of Sattal*



In the forests of Sattal, Uttarakhand, where sunlight filters softly through oak and pine, the morning began with a melody of wings. The forest was alive — every rustle, every chirp whispered the secrets of the Himalayas.

Then, from the shadowed bushes, emerged a burst of color — the Red-bellied Leiothrix, a tiny bird glowing with shades of gold, green, and scarlet. It perched gracefully on a mossy branch, as if nature herself had painted it with love.

Time just slowed down. The mist, the songs, and the gentle eyes of that little bird reflected the very soul of Sattal — peaceful, vibrant, and divine.

# *The Treasures of the Ghats – Birding Journey to Coorg*



It was still dark when we began our journey from Puttur, our hearts filled with excitement for the day ahead. Our birding team — Suresh Kamath, Arun Santhosh, Venkatrya Malya, Avinash Adapa, and I — packed our breakfast and lunch, ready for a long day surrounded by nature's beauty. As the car climbed the winding Western Ghats, the cool mist hugged the hills, and the gentle sound of flowing streams followed us along the road.

We stopped near a sparkling water stream in the ghat to enjoy our breakfast. The sound of rushing water, the chill of the morning breeze, and the first sunlight touching the forest created a peaceful start to our adventure. After breakfast, we continued toward our birding spot in Coorg, exploring the dense greenery and listening to the melodies of the forest. By noon, we had lunch amidst coffee plantations, the aroma of blossoms mixing with the earthy smell of rain-soaked soil.

As the golden evening sunlight filled the woods, the forest gifted us two magical moments — a Flame-throated Bulbul, glowing like fire among the leaves, and later a Grey-headed Bulbul, perched elegantly on a mossy branch.

Our photography in Coorg became more than just a birding trip. It was a story of friendship, patience, and the quiet joy of being one with nature. A reminder that true happiness takes flight when hearts travel together in the wild.



# *The Call of the Hills*



Darjeeling felt like a dream — clouds drifting low, hills wrapped in silence, and the scent of rain in the mountain air. Alongside my birding friend Debpratim Shah, I wandered through the emerald slopes, camera ready, heart open to the wild.

Then, from the tall fig tree, came a sudden flutter — a magnificent Oriental Pied Hornbill appeared, its curved bill gleaming in the soft mountain light. With every call echoing through the valley, it felt as though the hills themselves were speaking.

The meeting of mist, mountain, and melody was magical. In its majestic flight, the hornbill carried the spirit of Darjeeling's forests — free, timeless, and full of grace.





# *A Jewel in the Rain – Common Emerald Dove of Durga WLS, Karkala*



It was a soft, rainy morning inside the lush Durga Wildlife Sanctuary, Karkala. Along with Shivashankar Sir, Rajmohan, and Kartik Bhat, we wandered quietly through the dripping forest, our eyes searching for movement among the green.

Then, in the middle of a mossy tree, we saw it — a Common Emerald Dove, shimmering like a jewel in the rain. Tiny droplets clung to its feathers, glistening like pearls on green silk. The gentle patter of rain, the hush of the forest, and that radiant bird. It all came together in a perfect frame.

The emerald dove reminded us that beauty shines brightest when nature wears her simplest dress — rain, silence, and grace.

# *The Whispering Song - Grey-headed Bulbul of Somvarpet, Coorg*



In the misty hills of Somvarpet, Coorg, the morning air was cool and filled with the fragrance of wild coffee flowers. Along with my birding friend Sathish Sarakki, I wandered through the wet leaves and soft breeze, listening to the melodies of the forest.

Then, on a slender branch, appeared a Grey-headed Bulbul — its olive-green body glowing softly against the mist, its grey crown glistening with dew. It sang a gentle tune, as if the forest itself was humming along. Every note carried the calm of Coorg's rain-wrapped beauty.

For a moment, everything else faded — only the bird, the mist, and the music remained. The Grey-headed Bulbul reminded us that peace doesn't shout; it sings softly in nature's voice.



# *The Watchful Guardian – Indian Eagle Owl of Hesaraghatta*



In the peaceful grasslands of Hesaraghatta, the morning sun filtered gently through the trees. Along with my birding friend Madhu Shekar, I stood still, camera in hand, listening to the whispers of nature. There, perched under the cool shade of a tree, sat a majestic Indian Eagle Owl — calm, powerful, and full of grace. His golden eyes gleamed like twin suns, watching the world in silent wisdom. The breeze moved softly through his feathers, yet he remained composed, the true monarch of the wild.

The “wise” owl taught us a quiet truth — that strength often rests in stillness, and even in the shade, dignity shines bright.

# *The Scarlet Pair – Red Avadavat of Mysore*



In the soft morning light of Mysore's grasslands, I wandered with my friends Suresh Kamath and Arun Santhosh Fernadis, our eyes scanning the golden reeds for a glimpse of color. Then, like sparks in sunlight, they appeared — a male and female Red Avadavat, perched side by side.

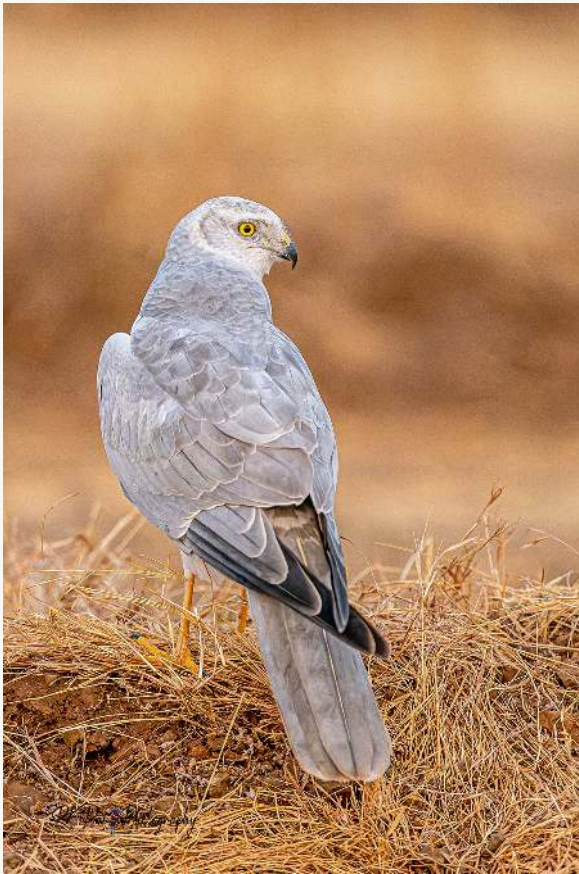
The male, glowing in bright crimson, shimmered like a ruby against the green. The female, calm and gentle, stood close — her soft brown hues complementing his fiery charm. Together they hopped from stalk to stalk, whispering a quiet love song only nature could compose.

In their tiny world of color and care, I saw a portrait of balance — beauty and simplicity, passion and peace. The Red Avadavat pair of Mysore reminded me that love, in its purest form, always finds a melody in togetherness.





# *The Silent Hunter – Pallid Harrier of Bhigwan*



During the monsoon mist at Bhigwan, the skies were heavy with clouds and the earth smelled of rain. In that calm grey morning, a male Pallid Harrier glided low over the wet fields — a shadow of grace and purpose.

With steady wings and sharp eyes, he scanned the flooded meadows. Suddenly, in a swift, perfect dive, he caught his prey — silent, sure, and strong. For a moment he stood still, rain droplets sliding down his silver feathers, the wild wind whispering around him.

This sight captured the soul of the monsoon — strength wrapped in stillness, elegance born from survival. The Pallid Harrier of Bhigwan showed that even in the rain-soaked world, a true hunter never loses his calmness or his focus.

# *Blue Jewel of Sattal – Ultramarine Flycatcher*



In the peaceful forests of Sattal, morning sunlight poured through the canopy, touching every leaf with golden light. As I waited near a quiet clearing, a sudden flash of deep blue caught my eye — the stunning Ultramarine Flycatcher had arrived.

Perched gracefully on a thin branch, its brilliant blue plumage shimmered like a piece of the sky come alive. It darted out to catch an insect mid-air, then returned to its perch, calm and elegant, as if posing for a painter's brush.

A timeless moment — a reminder that the smallest wings can carry the grandest colours, and nature's art needs no canvas but light and silence.





# *A Visitor to Paradise – Asian Paradise Flycatcher, Mangaluru*



One fine morning at Paradise, Mangaluru, the forest canopy glowed in soft golden light. As I moved silently along the trail, a flash of pure white — a bird with a long, flowing tail — caught my eye — the male Paradise Flycatcher, a graceful visitor from far lands.

With its elegant tail streaming like silk in the breeze, it darted between branches, catching tiny insects mid-air. Every turn of its wings seemed like a dance choreographed by nature itself.

This migratory beauty, though here only for a season, filled the forest with charm and wonder, reminding me that even a brief visit from such a guest can make a place truly live up to its name — Paradise.

# *The Rain King – Changeable Hawk Eagle of Manjalpade*



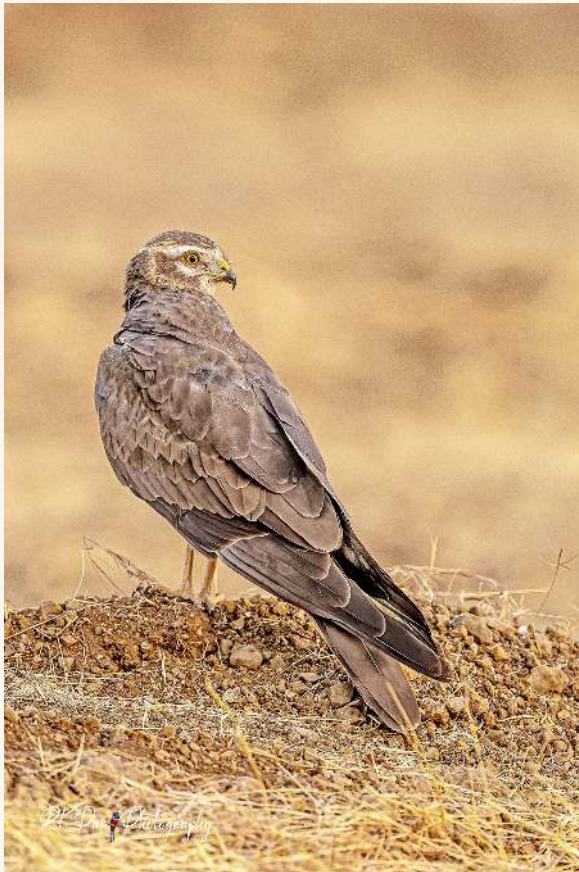
It was a calm, rainy Sunday at Manjalpade, when the mist hung low over the trees. My friends Abhay Yelloore, Vaman Kamath, Vivek Nayak, and I stood still, cameras in hand, watching nature reveal one of its regal moments.

Perched high on a branch sat the Changeable Hawk Eagle, feathers soaked from the morning rain. As the drizzle stopped, he lifted his mighty wings wide — each feather glistening with droplets, each movement full of grace and pride. He wasn't just drying his wings; he was reclaiming his throne in the wild.

The scene spoke of resilience — how even after the storm, life spreads its wings again. That Sunday, under grey skies and soft rain, the eagle reminded us that strength shines brightest after the rain.



# *The Elegant Hunter – Montagu's Harrier of Bhigwan*



At the vast grasslands of Bhigwan, where the golden light of morning meets the cool mist, I spotted a graceful shadow gliding low above the fields — the Montagu's Harrier.

With wings stretched wide and eyes sharp with focus, it floated silently, scanning the ground for prey. Every move was calm yet powerful, like a master of the winds.

Watching this migratory raptor in its natural rhythm was a moment of pure wonder — a reminder that beauty often lies in the balance of strength and serenity.

# *Song of the Shola – Nilgiri Sholakili of Ooty*



The cool breeze of Ooty's shola forests carried the fragrance of wet earth and wild blossoms. As I walked through the dense green canopy, every rustle felt alive with mystery. Then, from the moss-covered branches, a soft, enchanting call broke the silence — it was the Nilgiri Sholakili, the shy songbird of the Western Ghats.

Its gentle song echoed through the mist, blending perfectly with the rhythm of the forest. I stood still, captivated by its calm beauty — a rare glimpse of the life that hides deep within the sholas.

Some of nature's finest music is heard only by those who walk slowly, listen deeply, and feel completely.





# *Wings of Blue – Blue-winged Minla of Sattal*



The early morning mist of Sattal wrapped the forest in soft silence. As the Sun slowly filtered through the treetops, a flash of blue and silver danced in the light — the graceful Blue-winged Minla had arrived.

Hopping from branch to branch, it glimmered like a tiny jewel against the green backdrop of the hills. Its chirps were gentle yet full of life, adding music to the calm morning air.

The Blue-winged Minla was a reflection that beauty in nature is not loud — it whispers softly through colours, movements, and the quiet joy of being alive.



# *A Morning at Manjalpade – Vernal Hanging Parakeet*



On a crisp morning at Manjalpade, my birding friends Vaman Kamath, Abhay Yelloore, Vivek Nayak, and I set out to explore the vibrant forest canopy. Amid the green foliage, a flash of bright green with hints of yellow swung gracefully from branch to branch — the Vernal Hanging Parakeet.

Its playful movements and melodic calls filled the morning air with life. We watched quietly as it nibbled on tender leaves, preened, and swayed effortlessly, a jewel in the midst of nature's greenery.

Simple moments in the forest, shared with friends and winged companions, become memories that linger forever.



# *A Journey to Pune – Striolated Bunting*



On the outskirts of Pune, the fields glowed in the soft light of dawn. Alongside my birding friend Sachin Bhoi, we were scanning the open landscape when a small flash of color caught our attention — the Striolated Bunting, a delicate migratory bird visiting from distant lands.

Perched atop a dry stalk, it sang softly, its striped plumage blending with the golden grass around. Each chirp seemed like a small story of a long journey, of winds crossed and seasons traveled.

It's a wonder that even the smallest travellers carry grand tales of endurance, migration, and the quiet poetry of nature.

# *The Forest Drummer – Brown-fronted Woodpecker of Sattal*



In the serene woods of Sattal, where mist floats between pine trees and sunlight dances on mossy trunks, I heard a rhythmic tapping — soft yet full of life. Following the sound, I found the little Brown-fronted Woodpecker, busy at work on an old tree.

Its tiny beak struck the bark with perfect rhythm, echoing like music through the still morning air. Each beat seemed to speak of persistence, patience, and the art of living close to nature.

In every corner of the forest, there's a drummer keeping time — a heartbeat of the wild, which adds rhythm to the song of the earth.



# *Rhythm of the Woods – Lesser Yellownape Woodpecker of Sattal*



In the quiet forests of Sattal, Uttarakhand, the morning mist still lingered among the tall trees. As the first rays of sunlight touched the trunks, a familiar rhythm echoed through the woods — the gentle drumming of a Lesser Yellownape Woodpecker.

Perched gracefully on an old tree, its yellow nape glowed like a spark of sunlight against the bark. Each tap of its beak was like a heartbeat of the forest — steady, patient, and full of life.

Sattal's story tells me that nature's music doesn't always come from songs — sometimes, it is carved in rhythm, through the simplest sounds of life.



# *Reward Beyond the Climb – Long-tailed Broadbill of Sattal*



At the misty forests of Sattal, Uttarakhand, the path to my dream sighting wasn't easy — a steep uphill climb through a narrow, winding passage tested every step and breath. But nature always rewards patience and effort.

At the top, amidst the tall trees and soft mountain light, there it was — the stunning Long-tailed Broadbill, glowing in shades of green, yellow, and blue, like a jewel among leaves.

All the fatigue vanished in that magical moment. Every climb, every drop of sweat was worth the sight — a reminder that true beauty often waits at the end of the hardest trails.





# *Memories of Thattekkad – Sri Lankan Frogmouth*



At the lush forests of Thattekkad, Kerala, I was blessed to photograph the elusive Sri Lankan Frogmouth — both male and female — during a wonderful birding session with Eldhose K.V.

He was more than just a guide; he was a passionate birder whose deep knowledge and love for nature made every moment unforgettable. I still remember his stories, his smile, and those beautiful mornings that began with Kerala puttu and kadale kari for breakfast before our birding trails.

Today, he is no more — but his spirit lives on in every click, every call of the forest, and every memory captured in Thattekkad's wild silence. A frame of nature's wonder and a tribute to a friend who taught me that true birding is a journey of the heart and soul.



# *Spotted Owlet — A Magical Moment at Pilikula*



It was one bright Sunday afternoon after a long birding session at Kenjar, Mangaluru. Our group — Mr. Vivek Nayak, Mr. Vaman Kamath, Mr. Abhay Yelloore, and Dr. Ashwin Sujir — had spent the entire morning exploring the serene landscapes, cameras in hand, hearts filled with excitement.

Since we had started very early, none of us had time for breakfast. Hunger began to take over after hours of walking under the sun. Sensing that, Dr. Sujir sir kindly invited all of us for lunch at the Pilikula Golf Club. The thought of a good meal and shade made everyone smile — it felt like a perfect way to end the morning's adventure.

As we waited for lunch, a familiar sound suddenly reached our ears — a soft “churrr churrr” call from somewhere outside. Vivek, ever alert, immediately said, “That’s a Spotted Owlet!” and rushed out to check. After a few minutes, he returned, excitement glowing in his eyes. “The owlet is perched on a wooden branch outside!” he said breathlessly. In a flash, we all ran out, picked up our cameras from the car, and began shooting this unexpected little beauty. The Spotted Owlet sat calmly, blinking in the mild afternoon light, a sight that made our hearts full. Just then, the sky turned dark and it started drizzling — the soft touch of the monsoon rain. We quickly ran back inside for shelter, drenched but happily laughing. In all that hurry, Vaman forgot his camera and left it near the spot. After lunch, we went back to collect it. And what a surprise awaited us! The same Spotted Owlet was sitting right on top of the camera, as if it had posed for us one last time! For a few moments, we all stood silent, amazed by the magic of nature. Then the cameras clicked again — this time, not just to capture the bird, but the feeling of wonder, laughter, and friendship that surrounded it. It was a lifetime memory, a story we will cherish forever — a gentle lesson that nature rewards patience and passion in the most unexpected way. We bowed our heads in gratitude — Thank you, Nature, for this beautiful and unforgettable gift!

# *A Jewel from Paradise – Black-backed Dwarf Kingfisher, Mangaluru*



At Paradise, Mangaluru, I was blessed to capture the tiny yet dazzling Black-backed Dwarf Kingfisher — a real gem of the Western Ghats. Its brilliant colours glowed like a real rainbow against the green forest background.

The moment became even more special in the company of Vivek Nayak and our passionate birding friends of Mangaluru. Every click echoed with excitement, laughter, and the shared joy of discovery.

It was truly a paradise moment — where friendship and nature met through the lens.



# *A Gift from the Hills – Cheer Pheasant of Ranikhet*



At the serene slopes of Ranikhet, Uttarakhand, I was blessed to witness a truly special sight — a male and female Cheer Pheasant together, glowing in the soft mountain light. Their gentle presence amidst the whispering pines felt like a divine reward for patience and passion.

Guided by the ever-knowledgeable bird guide Pankaj, the moment became even more meaningful — a perfect blend of nature's grace and heartfelt joy. This Himalayan memory remains a beautiful gift from nature, captured forever through the lens.





# *Elegance at Ghajaldoba – Northern Pintail*



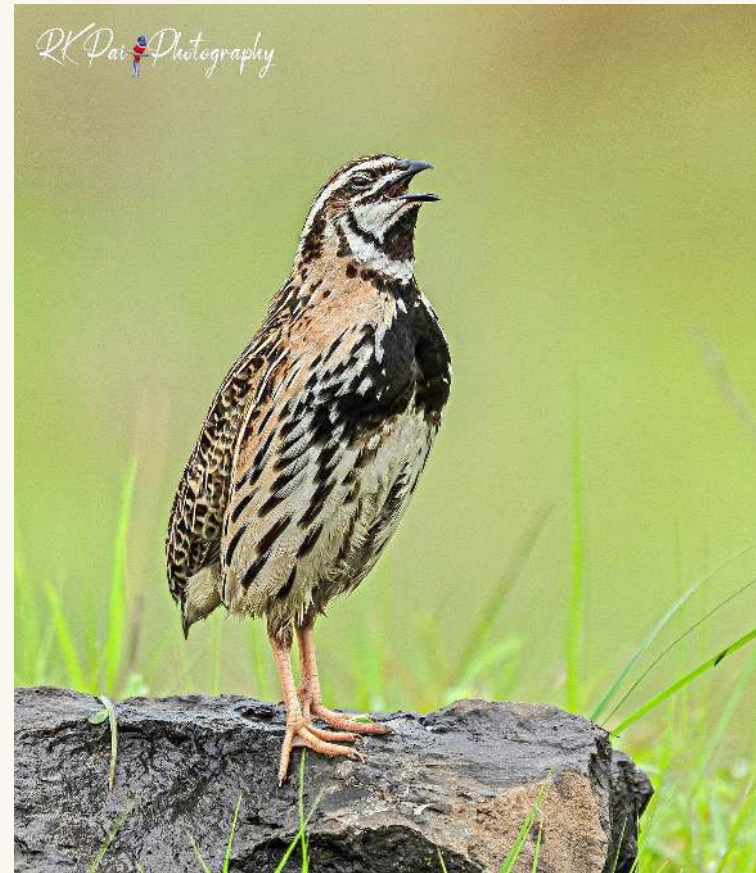
On the serene wetlands of Ghajaldoba, West Bengal, I had the joy of capturing the graceful Northern Pintail in the golden light of dawn. The bird's long, slender neck and smooth flight reflected pure elegance in motion.

Sharing this wonderful birding experience with Depratim Shah, Arun, Santhosh Fernadis, and Suresh Kamath made it even more special — a perfect blend of friendship, photography, and nature's calm beauty.

# *Rain Quail — The Melody of Bhigwan*



In the rocky plains of Bhigwan, I was delighted to capture a charming Rain Quail perched gracefully on the top of a rock, its soft call blending with the calm drizzle. It was magical — the fragrance of wet earth, the rhythm of rain, and the quiet joy of nature. Sharing the sight with Sachin Bhoi made it even more memorable — a perfect harmony of friendship and wildness.



# *The Gem of Chafi – Crested Kingfisher of Sattal*



Amid the clear streams of Chafi, Sattal (Uttarakhand), I captured the majestic Crested Kingfisher — a true monarch of the mountain rivers. Its striking crest, bold black-and-white plumage, and piercing eye reflected the spirit of the wild Himalayas.

Nature's artistry at its best and Kushbo Sharma's presence was simply perfect.



# *The Watchers of Masinagudi – Spotted Owlet Family*



In the quiet corners of Masinagudi, where the forest whispers to the wind, a hollow tree became a home to a charming family of Spotted Owlets.

Peeping from their cozy nest, the tiny owlets sat close together, their bright yellow eyes full of curiosity and mischief. The parent owls watched protectively, keeping a keen eye on every rustle in the leaves.

In the morning, as sunlight filtered through the canopy, I captured a glimpse of love, care, and togetherness in the wild — family is nature's truest comfort.



# *A Moment with My Mentor – Blue-faced Malkoha of Durga WLS*



In the lush forests of Durga Wildlife Sanctuary, Karkala, I was birding with my mentor Shivashankar Sir, whose deep love for nature always inspires me. As we moved quietly through the dense foliage, a gentle rustle caught our attention.

There it was — the Blue-faced Malkoha, with its long tail and shimmering blue facial skin, moving gracefully among the branches. Its calm presence and subtle beauty filled the forest with charm.

With my mentor, sharing silence and wonder, reminded me that birding is not just about finding birds — it's about finding peace, patience, and inspiration in nature's company.



# *The Blue Charm of Mookambika – Black-naped Monarch*



In the dense evergreen forests of Mookambika Wildlife Sanctuary, Kollur (Udupi District), I had the pleasure of birding with Jayaprakash Sir, a respected judge by profession and a passionate bird watcher and photography lover at heart.

As we walked beneath the tall canopy, sunlight filtered through the leaves, creating patterns of gold and green. Suddenly, a flash of azure darted through the shade — the elegant Black-naped Monarch. Its graceful movements and soft trilling notes added melody to the still forest air.

We stood silently, admiring its royal blue beauty as it flitted from branch to branch, a symbol of calm and focus — much like Jayaprakash Sir himself.

A lesson in nature: every encounter carries wisdom — of patience, harmony, and the quiet dignity of life.



*Black-capped Kingfisher — A Memorable Zuari  
River Experience, Goa*



The Zuari River in Goa greeted us with the first blush of morning light — calm waters flowing silently through rich mangrove forests. Though my primary purpose for visiting Goa was to attend a Ramco Cement Dealer Conference, my passion for birds gently changed the course of the morning. With excitement in my heart, I planned an early bird photography session, hoping nature would surprise me.

The journey along the river felt like entering another world — a world ruled not by concrete and machines, but by wings, tides and whispers of the mangroves. The region is home to around 15 types of *Avicennia* (different species of mangroves), each supporting a unique ecosystem. Under the knowledgeable guidance of experts who shared incredible insights about these forests and the birds relying on them, every moment became a learning experience.

And then... the moment I had dreamed of arrived! A Black-capped Kingfisher — a rare jewel of Indian wetlands — suddenly appeared on a perfect perch. Its striking blue wings, crimson bill, and glossy black cap turned the dull riverbank into a canvas of vibrant colours. My heart raced as I clicked. Each frame captured not just a bird, but a story, an emotion and an unforgettable memory.

Adding more glory to that moment, I was in the wonderful company of Dr. D. M. Kamath Sir, a passionate and respected birder. His presence, knowledge, and enthusiasm made the experience even more enriching. We both admired the beauty in silence — a silence that spoke thousands of words that morning.

This photograph is not just a picture in my collection — it is a treasure of experience, a symbol of curiosity that led me from a business conference hall... to the heart of nature's paradise.

A reminder that whenever passion calls, we must follow, because some of life's best memories are found between plans, in the unexpected joy of the wild.

# *The Nine-Colored Visitor – Indian Pitta of Paradise, Mangaluru*



It was a calm morning at Paradise, Mangaluru, where the forest still held the freshness of dawn. Along with my Mangaluru Birding friends, I walked through the quiet trails, listening to the hum of insects and the rustle of fallen leaves.

Then came a magical moment from the dense undergrowth — a flash of rainbow hues appeared. The Indian Pitta, with its nine brilliant colours, hopped gracefully onto a branch, glowing in the soft sunlight.

We stood still, our cameras forgotten for a second, simply admiring this tiny jewel of the forest. That brief meeting was a lesson in nature: true beauty lives quietly in nature's heart — waiting for those who seek it with love and patience.





# *The Caring Father – Red Spurfowl of Paradise, Mangaluru*



In the quiet corners of Paradise, Mangaluru, early morning sunlight danced through the green leaves. There, on a soft forest trail, a beautiful Red Spurfowl stepped proudly beside his tiny chick. Unlike many other birds, it was the male Spurfowl who took charge — guiding the little one with care and courage.

He gently scratched the earth, finding seeds and insects, softly calling his chick to eat. Every rustle in the bushes made him alert — his eyes sharp, his stance protective. Yet between those moments of watchfulness, he showed tenderness, letting the chick rest close under his wing.

This heartwarming scene showed that love and responsibility aren't bound by roles — they belong to every heart that cares. In the wild, this devoted father taught us the truest meaning of family and protection.



# *The Frame Born in Paradise – Malabar Trogon of Alangar, Vittal*



5:30 a.m. — Alangar, Vittal. The first rays of light kissing the morning mist. Rangaraj Prabhu and I, carrying dreams woven into our cameras. A cup of hot tea, the sweetness of “Marie” biscuits, and the soft music of awakening birds — that was the first chapter of our dawn.

After the colourful celebration of many birds, we spoke our wish aloud: “The jewel of the Western Ghats — the Malabar Trogon... If only it sits before us on a perfect perch!” As if nature had heard our whisper, suddenly, the call of the Trogon! Our hearts skipped a beat... The camera in our hands felt weightless for a moment — a tremor of pure joy!

In that canvas of shifting shadows, the rare artist appeared — red, black and white in divine harmony... The Trogon sat exactly where our dreams had imagined. Click... click... Time froze. And that moment became an eternal memory.

We couldn’t leave that place unnamed. How could we? We called it “Paradise.” Even today, that very name gives us goosebumps. On that day, it wasn’t just the Trogon we captured... We captured our confidence, our spirit, our dream itself.

# *The Grace of Bhigwan Waters – Greater Flamingo*



At Bhigwan, the shimmering backwaters stretch endlessly under the morning sun. To reach the flamingo point, we began a one-hour boat journey, gliding over calm waters surrounded by flocks of ducks and waders.

As the boat slowed near the far end of the lake, a vision unfolded — hundreds of Greater Flamingos, standing tall and elegant, painting the blue water with shades of pink and white. Their synchronized movements reflected like poetry on the rippling surface.

The long journey, the still air, and the distant calls of birds created a serene magic. That morning reminded me — true beauty often lies beyond the distance, waiting for those who travel with patience and love for nature.



# *Booted Eagle – The Silent Monarch of Konchady*



In the warm light of morning at Konchady, Mangaluru, as the coastal breeze carried the scent of earth and rain, the Booted Eagle appeared — silent, calm, and commanding.

Perched on a high branch above the fields, it watched the world with ancient, golden eyes, a guardian spirit of Mangaluru's wild sky. Its feathered boots, soft yet regal, glowed in the sun like symbols of quiet strength. We stood with our birding friends, sharing whispers, smiles, and the thrill of rare beauty, as the eagle lifted its wings with effortless grace. In that single rising moment, the world below faded... and only the poetry of flight remained. A memory carved forever — Konchady, friends, and the soaring soul of the Booted Eagle.





# *Bhigwan Memory – Yellow-eyed Babbler*





Bhigwan — a land that glows like a mirror of water, a sacred sanctuary for birds beyond the quiet ripples of its wetlands. Morning drops drifting like rain, the breeze carrying the scent of memories. The pages of our bird friendship still float softly in that very air.

In the arms of the blue sky, above the dancing reeds, the Yellow-eyed Babbler greeted us — a tiny body... wrapped in immense curiosity. Those lightning-bright yellow eyes, the gentle play of grey and brown feathers, the graceful dance of its long tail, and its art of balancing on thorny twigs were nothing short of magic.

Its little neck full of mischief, its buttermilk-coloured belly, and the restless song beating in its heart seemed to whisper: “Do not fade away from life; every fleeting glance carries a hope of its own.”

The moments we shared through binoculars, the friendship framed through camera clicks, the laughter echoing across those sunlit hours — they still drift through our minds like unwritten verses.

In the pages of 2025, this bird and Bhigwan together etched an everlasting mark on the landscape of our birding journey...

# *Plum-headed Parakeet in Flight – Sattal, Uttarakhand*



In the quiet breath of a Sattal morning, when the Himalayan mist drifts like a soft prayer, a flash of colours breaks the silence — the Plum-headed Parakeet, rising like a dream set free.

With wings dipped in the palette of dawn, it glides across the sky as if painting its own destiny. The purple crown glows like a sacred jewel, the emerald body shimmers with the heartbeat of the forest. For a brief, eternal moment, the world pauses to admire this flying poem.

Its gentle arc over the lake is a whisper of freedom, a reminder that beauty needs no stage — only the open sky and a quiet heart to behold it.

# *Narayana – The Boatman of Kodi (Osprey)*



The calm waters of Kodi, a small beach near Kundapur, sparkled in the soft glow of dawn. Our birding group began early from the mangroves, eager to explore this hidden paradise where countless migratory birds and waders visit every season.

We hired a small fishing boat, guided by a humble boatman named Narayana. He knew nothing about bird photography or the names of the species — he knew only the rhythm of the waves and the secrets of the sea breeze. As we floated along, the golden light revealed a majestic Osprey perched on a wooden pole, its sharp eyes scanning the waters for prey.

The morning turned into a lesson in beauty and simplicity. Narayana watched us with curiosity, slowly learning about birds, lenses, and the joy of patience.

Today, he is no longer just a fisherman. He is “Narayana, the Boatman of Kodi” — now known among birders as a knowledgeable companion, guiding visitors through the waterways of his beloved island with pride and passion.





*Bhigwan's Desert Melody – Chestnut-bellied  
Sandgrouse*



RK Pai Photography

Bhigwan — where the dry earth meets the quiet rhythm of the wind, and the horizon glows like a golden line drawn by nature herself.

In this wide, open canvas, life hides in colours subtle and earthy. And among them, the Chestnut-bellied Sandgrouse moves like a whisper of the desert breeze — calm, alert, timeless.

The morning sun had just begun to paint the land in warm amber. Hours passed as I scanned the vast scrublands, following footprints, shadows, and the soft crunch of dry leaves.

Then, like a blessing of patience, they appeared — their chestnut bellies glowing, their feathers blending so perfectly with Bhigwan's soil that only a trained eye could separate bird from earth, life from silence. One Sandgrouse paused, looked back with gentle curiosity, and stood still long enough for the camera to breathe in the moment.

A frame born from stillness... from waiting... from understanding the language of the land. Bhigwan gifted me not just a photograph, but a memory etched in the quiet heartbeat of the wild.



# *Voice of the Understory – Puff-throated Babbler of Coorg*



In the cool misty woods of Coorg, where sunlight filters softly through tall trees, I wandered along a quiet forest trail listening to the melodies of the Western Ghats. Suddenly, from the shadowed undergrowth, came a gentle yet lively call — the Puff-throated Babbler.

It appeared briefly, hopping among the dry leaves, its puffed throat moving rhythmically as it sang its forest tune. Small, shy, and full of charm, it carried the spirit of the hidden jungle life.

This sighting in Coorg reminded me how beauty often hides in the quiet corners of nature, waiting to be seen by those who listen with their hearts.

# *Whispers of Thattekkad – Malabar Grey Hornbill*



In the lush green canopies of Thattekkad, the morning sunlight filtered through the tall trees, painting them in shades of gold and green. As I waited in quiet anticipation, a deep flutter broke the stillness — a magnificent Malabar Grey Hornbill appeared, gliding gracefully between branches.

Its long curved bill and gentle eyes reflected the ancient soul of the Western Ghats. Perched high, it called out in its distinct voice, echoing through the vastness like a timeless song.

This fleeting encounter in Thattekkad was more than just a sighting — it was a glimpse into the living rhythm of the rainforest, where every sound, colour, and flight becomes poetry in motion.



# *Charm at Kenjar – Bluethroat*



One calm morning at Kenjar, Mangaluru, I set out with my birding friends, the air fresh with the promise of new sightings. The fields shimmered with dew, and the soft light revealed a delightful surprise — a Bluethroat, that tiny traveler from distant lands, belonging to the thrush family.

It perched gracefully near a puddle, its shimmering blue throat catching the morning light like a sapphire gem. Every movement reflected elegance and energy, as if it carried the spirit of migration in its wings.

This meeting between worlds was pure joy — where nature whispered its timeless story through the eyes of a little migratory bird.

# *Voices of the Jungles – Rufous Babbler of Vittal*



In the quiet hills near Vittal, the morning air was cool and filled with the whispers of rustling leaves. Along with my birding friend Zamir Pasha, I wandered through the forest paths, listening to the rhythm of nature waking up.

Then came a burst of cheerful chatter — a group of Rufous Babblers, their warm brown feathers glowing in the soft light. One of them paused on a low branch, its curious eyes sparkling as if sharing a secret of the woods.

Their lively calls filled the air with joy and friendship. Every forest has its storytellers — small, humble voices that bring the wilderness to life.





# *Echoes at Hesaraghatta – Siberian Stonechat*



In the vast golden grasslands of Hesaraghatta, I spent a memorable morning with my birding friend Madhu Aditya. The air was cool, and the rustling grass whispered the songs of old birding days that now live only in memories.

As we explored the open fields, a tiny traveler from distant lands caught our eyes — a Siberian Stonechat, perched gracefully on a dry stem. The little migratory bird seemed to enjoy the warmth of the Indian winter, its bright eyes gleaming with curiosity.

It was a simple yet magical sight — a reminder of how fleeting beauty can be. Though Hesaraghatta is now a restricted place, the memories of that morning and the charm of the Siberian Stonechat remain forever in my heart.



# *The Winter Guest – Gurupura*



Every year, as the northern winds grow cold, the skies above Gurupura welcome their distant travelers — the migratory birds. They arrive with the dawn, wings stretched wide, carrying stories from lands beyond the horizon.

One such morning, amid the golden light and gentle breeze, I watched a lone bird rest upon a dry wooden stump set against the laterite stones. Its eyes reflected both strength and serenity — a tiny wanderer who had crossed mountains, rivers, and oceans to find peace here.

I felt the rhythm of migration — a journey of hope, courage, and timeless connection. Nature's message was clear: even the smallest wings can travel great distances when guided by purpose and the heart's direction.



# *Leopard and Cub — Moments from the Heart of Maasai Mara*



My journey into the wild took a grand new turn when I set foot in Maasai Mara, Kenya — my very first international trip for wildlife photography. The name Mara itself echoes adventure, wilderness, and wonder. With my mentors and companions Saravana Sundaram Sir and Madanraj, this expedition became not just a trip, but a treasure of unforgettable memories.

The African savannah stretched endlessly before us — golden grasslands dancing in the wind, acacia trees standing like silent guardians, and the air alive with the rhythm of nature. Every direction offered a story waiting to be seen, framed, and remembered.

And then, as if nature wished to gift us her finest moment, we saw a leopard and her cub resting gracefully on a sunlit rock. The mother's sharp eyes glowed with strength and protection, while the cub curiously watched the world, its tiny tail twitching with playful energy.

I lifted my camera, hands trembling with excitement — the lens found them framed perfectly by the wild. Each click captured not just their beauty, but the emotion of motherhood, the bond of the wild, and the thrill of being there, right at the heart of nature's kingdom.

That moment felt timeless — the silence, the soft light, and the heartbeat of the wild all merging into one unforgettable experience. As the evening sun set behind the endless plains, painting the sky in hues of gold and crimson, I realized this trip had given me more than photographs. It had given me a perspective — a deeper respect for life in its rawest, purest form.

Maasai Mara was not just a destination; it was a dream come alive. A memory etched forever — of a leopard, her cub, and the heartbeat of Africa.



# *The Swift Spirit – Cheetah of Maasai Mara*



Across the golden grasslands of Maasai Mara, Kenya, the wind whispered softly, carrying the scent of freedom. There, under the wide African sky, a cheetah stood poised — sleek, silent, and stunning.

For a few seconds, time seemed to pause. The cheetah's amber eyes scanned the horizon, every muscle ready, every breath calm. Then, with a burst of effortless speed, it sprinted across the plains — the fastest heart of the savannah in motion.

When it finally slowed down, standing tall against the sunset, it wasn't just a predator I saw — it was a symbol of grace, focus, and wild beauty. The cheetah of Maasai Mara reminded me that true strength lies not only in speed, but in the quiet confidence before the leap.



# *The King of Maasai Mara — A Majestic Moment*



In the endless golden grasslands of Maasai Mara, Kenya, I witnessed the true king of the wild — the Lion — resting with pride and power under the morning sun. Every glance from those fierce yet calm eyes spoke of strength, authority, and timeless beauty.

It was my first encounter with Africa's royal predator, a moment when silence itself bowed to nature's majesty. The vast savanna, the distant roars, and the golden light — all came together to gift me an experience beyond words.

A frame that will forever remind me — wildlife is not just seen, it is felt deep within.



Dear Annu,  
I wish you a very HAPPY BIRTHDAY.

Like the amazing photos you capture,  
May you capture all the happiness in the world, I pray.

Like the sweet aroma of the delicious food that you cook,  
May the ambience of your pure heart spread everywhere you look.

Like the wonderful artworks and those beautiful scenes  
you paint on canvas for the world to see,

I wish I could show the world what the canvas can't hold;  
the limitless joy and laughter that you paint in the lives  
of Amma, Shreya and me.

Seriously, how blessed are we?!

While I pray for your great health and inner peace,  
I could go on and write pages on you Annu but,  
Our love for you and your love for us is an endless ocean  
that a poem can't do justice.

For you dad, You are god's true  
Masterpiece!!



HAPPY

BIRTHDAY

ANNU ♥





# Acknowledgment



Thanks to each and every one who made the publication of this book possible. This dream could not have been fulfilled without the blessings, love, and encouragement of my family members, teachers, friends, well-wishers, and supporters who stood by me in every step. Their constant motivation and guidance helped me bring this book to light.

*My Family Members* : Anuradha Pai, Shraddha Pai, Shreya Pai, Subraya Pai, Divya Pai, Puttur  
Narasimha Nayak, Kalpana Nayak, Dr. K. G. Shenoy, Shubhakiran Shenoy

*Friends* : Rangaraj Prabhu, Vidhya Sharma, Rajmohan M. R., Prashanth Poojari,  
Kartik Bhat, Vivek Nayak, Avinash Adapa, Arun Santhosh Fernadis,  
Suresh Kamath, Abhay Yelloore, Venkatrya Malya, Vaman Kamath,  
Veenith Prabhu, Dr. Ashwin Sujir, Ranganath Bhatt, Arvinda Kudla,  
Teelaksha Vittal, Pavi Photo Frames Vittal, Radha Muliya

*Mentors* : Sri Ullas Kamath, Anantha Krishna Hebbar, Shridhar Kodakkal,  
Arundhati Dhareshwar, Rajesh Srivana, Late Keshava Vittal, Late Keshava  
Nayak, Late Madhumathi akka, Shri Sudhakar Mam, Shivashankar Karkala,  
Arnould Govius

*Printers* : K Venkatesh Bhat, K Pradeep Bhat  
Hanuman Printers, Vittal

*Creative Design* : Vrathik Shenoy K  
*& Digital Experience*

*With gratitude and love,*

P. Radhakrishna Pai  
*Mathru Kripa, Vittal*











# Feather Fables



— Tales from the Wings and the Wild —



RK Pai Photography

By  
P. Radhakrishna Pai

